The Boy Who Gave His Name to the Police

A true Petersen family adventure

Everything in this story comes from old church books, census lists, police records, newspapers, and gravestones. Where the papers go quiet, the story says so. Nothing is made up.

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1. A Baby With a Puzzle

In February 1833, in a tiny Danish village called Valsømagle, a baby boy was born. His name was Hans Pedersen.

Denmark is a small country north of Germany, and Valsømagle sat on its biggest island, Zealand. About a month later, on Palm Sunday, baby Hans was baptized in Haraldsted church, about two miles away. The priest wrote his name in the big church book.

And that is where the puzzle begins.

Hans's mother was a young servant girl, and she was not married. The baptism book named a man, Peder Johansen of Ringsted, a town about four miles away, as the father. That was the name his mother gave, and the confirmation book lists him again years later. So his name is locked in the records. But was Peder really his father? No paper proves it, and nobody knows, even today.

A few weeks after baby Hans was baptized, around 1 May 1833, his mother left the village to work as a servant girl in Ringsted. The church book says so. But Ringsted's books do not show where in town she arrived. That part is still a mystery.

His mother's name was Ane Marie Hansdatter. (One old book seemed to spell it differently, but that turned out to be a wrong reading.) Family researchers also found an old record of a couple from her village promising to marry at the Haraldsted parsonage, the priest's house next to the church, in 1797. They *might* be her parents, but nobody knows for sure yet.

A year later, the government counted the people of Ringsted. On a street called Sankt Hans Gade (it is still on the map in Ringsted today), the counters wrote down a servant named Peter Johansen, about 30, not married. He was a *tjenestekarl*, a hired man who worked in someone else's house. The researchers checked carefully: he is the same man the church books name as Hans's father. Now we know a little about him! But the books only say the mother *named* him; nobody can prove he really was the father. And here is a maybe: on that same street the counters also wrote down a servant girl named Ane Marie Hansdatter, 27. Was she Hans's mother? Maybe. Nobody knows for sure, and the list does not show her living with Peter. It is a clue, not an answer.

So here is a baby with a big question mark about his father. What would happen to him?

2. The Wheelwright's Cottage

Before his first birthday, Hans was living somewhere new.

Three miles from where he was born, in a village called Skee, stood the cottage of Jens Nielsen and his wife, Kirsten. Hans became their foster child. That means they raised him, even though they were not his birth parents.

Jens was a wheelwright. A wheelwright builds and fixes wooden wheels for wagons and carts. In a world with no cars, wagons were everything, and so was the person who kept their wheels turning.

Every few years the government counted everyone in the country. That count is called a census. In 1834, 1840, and 1845, the census takers came to the cottage in Skee. All three times, Hans was there. First they called him "foster child." Later they called him "foster son."

Back then, Denmark was ruled by a king who had all the power. There was no parliament, no voting. And Haraldsted was already an old, old place: more than 700 years before Hans was born, a duke named Knud Lavard was murdered in the forest nearby, and people walked there as pilgrims.

At fourteen, Hans stood in Haraldsted church again for his confirmation, a big church day for teenagers back then. In fact, it was the law: every Danish teen had to be confirmed, and pass a test to do it. The priest wrote him down as "Hans Pedersen of Skee."

Then, by 1850, Hans had left the cottage.

Where did he go? For twelve whole years, the records go completely silent. Not one paper. Hans vanishes.

Until 1862.

3. A Wedding, and Hard Years

In October 1862, Hans married Ane Rasmusdatter in Bjernede church, about eight miles from where he was born. The church book said what he did for work: **wheelwright.** The boy from the wheelwright's cottage was making wheels himself.

Soon a baby boy was born to them. He died the very next day, before he even had a name.

In February 1864, another son was born. This one lived. He was baptized Hans Peder Pedersen, but we know him as **Hans Peter**. Remember that name. He is the hero of the next part of this story.

Hans Peter was born in a war year. That spring Denmark fought a war against Prussia and Austria, and lost. Nothing in the records says that his dad or anyone in the family was a soldier. But Denmark was changing in other ways too. The king no longer ruled alone: since 1849 Denmark had a constitution and a parliament. And a train line now ran through Ringsted and Sorø, close to Bjernede. Bjernede's church was special as well: it is round, the only old round church left on the whole island of Zealand.

Then came a third son, Rasmus, born in December 1866. He died that winter, still a tiny baby.

Back then, before modern doctors and medicine, many babies did not survive.

And there was more sadness coming.

4. Three and a Half Years Old

Seven months after baby Rasmus died, in September 1867, Hans Pedersen died. He was only 34. He was buried in Bjernede churchyard. Bjernede church is round — people still call it Zealand's only round church — and it is still there today.

His son Hans Peter was three and a half.

In 1870, the census taker found them in Bjernede: Ane, a 27-year-old widow, and her son, "Hans Peter Pedersen, 6."

That spring, Ane married again. Her new husband, Hans Rasmussen, was a much older man whose wife had died. Hans Peter now had a stepfather, and soon a little half-brother, Rasmus Peter, and a little half-sister, Ane Marie.

Hans Peter was confirmed on Palm Sunday 1878. In 1880, at 15, he was still living at home.

Then came the summer of 1883.

5. The Summer Everything Ended

On June 29, 1883, Hans Rasmussen's wife died. That was almost surely Hans Peter's mother, Ane. Just a few days later, Hans Rasmussen died too.

In one summer, the whole household was gone.

Hans Peter was nineteen. His young half-brother and half-sister went to foster homes, the same way his father had grown up long before.

The next spring, Hans Peter did something that would change everything for our family.

6. Alone, Age Twenty

On April 16, 1884, in the big city of Copenhagen, about 40 miles from Bjernede, the police wrote some words in a thick book. Anyone leaving Denmark for America had to be written down.

Hans Peter Petersen. Of Bjernede. Age 20. Going to Springfield, Minnesota. Traveling alone.

Alone.

Twenty years old. His father had died when he was three. His mother and stepfather were gone. And he was heading across an ocean to a place he had never seen.

Why did he go? The record doesn't say. What ship did he take? It doesn't say that either. Those answers are lost.

But here's something to think about. That November, back in Bjernede, his stepfather's property was sold to a miller for 13,000 kroner (Danish money). Part of the money was saved for the two young half-siblings. Hans Peter's name wasn't in the sale at all.

He was already gone.

7. A Farm on the Prairie

Hans Peter made it. Every American census after that agrees he arrived in 1884.

He settled in Brookville Township, Redwood County, Minnesota, about 22 miles from Springfield, the town he had named in Copenhagen. On March 11, 1891, in the town of Redwood Falls, he married Maren Sophia Jensen (the marriage record spells her "Mary S. Jensen"). Two people signed as witnesses: Niels Jensen and J. L. Byram. Maren was born in 1872, the daughter of Nels Peter Jensen and Anne Marie Hansen Jensen.

Then the farm grew, and so did the family.

In 1900, the census found Hans Peter farming, with five children. In 1905 the state counted them again: Hans Peter was 41, Maren was 32, and Anna was 10. By 1910 he **owned** his farm. By 1920 it was a dairy farm he ran for himself. It still had a loan on it, called a mortgage. And that census tells us something big: back in 1897, the boy from Bjernede had become an **American citizen.**

Hans Peter and Maren Sophia had eight children: Nels, Rudolph, Annie, Louis, Mary, Ethel, Elmer, and Olga.

One of those babies matters a lot to us. He was born on March 24, 1906, and when the state wrote down his birth, it didn't use a real name. It wrote **"Babe" Petersen.**

Babe grew up to be called **Elmer.**

8. The Chair

In September 1922, the local newspaper printed sad news.

Hans P. Petersen, 55, of Brookville Township, about two miles east of the Brookville church, had died suddenly one afternoon of heart trouble while sitting in a chair. The paper said he had been ailing for some time. (Another old list spells his name "Hans T." and gives the day as September 6. Is that a mistake? Nobody has checked the death certificate yet, so it is still a mystery.)

He was buried at Dannebod Cemetery, the graveyard of the township's Danish church. Maren Sophia is buried there too. (A website called Find a Grave tells us this; we'd like to find more records to be sure.) The cemetery is still on a country road near the little town of Cobden.

The boy who left Copenhagen alone had built a farm, a family, and a whole new life.

Now it was Elmer's turn.

9. Farm Boys and a Paratrooper

Elmer grew up on his father's Brookville farm. Around 1931 he married Caroline Schultz, born in Sundown Township in the same county. They had two sons, Darvin and **Donald**.

Darvin, the big brother, was born in 1932. He served in the U.S. Air Force during the Korean War and spent his working life in aviation. He married Anna Maye Hansen at the same Lutheran church in Morgan where his parents are buried, and they had five children: Dwight, Daniel, Diana, Douglas, and Deborah. Darvin died in 2007 and was buried back home in Morgan, in the Bethany Lutheran church cemetery. Anna Maye was later buried there too.

Donald was born on July 23, 1935. When he grew up, he served in the U.S. Army with the **82nd Airborne**, the paratroopers, soldiers trained to jump out of airplanes.

In 1957, Donald married Janice Dohrmann at the Methodist church in Sleepy Eye, Minnesota (Brown County). They farmed in Paxton Township, the second generation on the family farm.

Their first baby, Randy, was born on July 30, 1958, and died that October, when he was not yet three months old. He is buried in Redwood Falls, and his small stone says he lived 2 1/2 months. Almost a hundred years after Bjernede, the family knew that sorrow again.

Then more boys came. Donald and Janice had five sons in all: Randy, Rick, **Michael**, Chad, and Bill. Michael was born on August 5, 1961.

Donald died young, at 44, in 1980, and is buried in Redwood Falls. Janice lived to 86 and died in Redwood Falls in 2025; she is buried in the same cemetery.

10. The Last Clue

Michael Petersen is your dad Alex's father.

Michael confirmed that the family went back to Hans Peter and Maren Sophia on the Minnesota farm. Then Alex did the detective work. He searched the old Danish church books and matched them to the same Hans Peter: the baby from Bjernede, the boy whose father died when he was three, the twenty-year-old the Copenhagen police wrote down as bound for Springfield, Minnesota.

Here is the whole chain:

Hans Pedersen, the foster boy from Skee → **Hans Peter**, who crossed the ocean alone → **Elmer**, the baby called "Babe" → **Donald**, the paratrooper farmer → **Michael → Alex → and you.**

This is your family line.

Some questions are still open. Who was Hans Pedersen's real father? Why did Hans Peter leave? What ship carried him? Nobody knows yet.

Maybe someday, one of you will find out.

What we know from the old papers: Danish church books and censuses, the Copenhagen police emigration register (1884), U.S. censuses (1900–1920), Minnesota birth and death indexes, a 1922 newspaper notice, family obituaries, and gravestones.